to eat except the carcasses of our camels and horses that have died from want of food. Twigs and the bark of trees was no longer procurable. All the trees in the Cantonments are stript.'[57]

Johnson soon identified the only feasible source of food: the Sufi-shrine village of Bibi Mahru ('Moon-Faced Lady'), known to the British as Bemaroo, which lay on a low ridge half a mile to the north, commanding the rear of the cantonment.[cc] Johnson eventually concluded negotiations with the headman, and a small quantity of wheat now arrived in the cantonment, but it was only enough for the needs of a few days.[58] To add to the misery, the temperature now dropped, and the first snows of winter began to dust the ground. Around the same time the insurgents began to bombard the cantonment with the cannon they had captured within the city and in the commissariat forts. There was little skill or method to the bombardment, and throughout the war the Afghans struggled to find trained gunners, but the random falling of shot within the cantonment walls still began to wear away at the nerves of the besieged troops.

The cannon fire was soon supplemented by volleys of musketry from the fort of Mohammad Sharif, captured by the rebels the following day. This looked straight on to the main gate of the cantonment, and flanked the road leading to the city. The Afghans, having walked in and captured it unopposed, had quickly loopholed the walls so as to shoot down any British attempt at sorties from their front gate. On 6 November, Elphinstone further stymied British resistance by forbidding returning fire from the walls on the grounds that 'powder is scarce!' wrote an incredulous Lady Sale. 'There being at the time sufficiency for a twelve month siege.'[59]

It was now clear to everyone that Elphinstone was a liability. 'People do not hesitate to say that our chief should be set aside,' noted Lady Sale in her diary. 'The poor general's mind is distracted by the diversity of opinions offered; and the great bodily ailments he sustains are daily enfeebling his powers. There is much reprehensible croaking going on: talk of retreat, and the consequent desertion of our Mussalmen troops. All this makes a bad impression on the men.'[60] This was certainly true: the troops were baffled and unnerved by the lack of leadership and the sudden loss of confidence. 'The spirits of the army were much depressed,' wrote the sepoy Sita Ram. 'There was fighting every day, and because there was no good food for the European soldiers, they lost spirit and did not fight as well as they used to.' To make matters worse,